



THE SCREEN

Scorchers

The multiplex revolution changed the formula of filmmaking. Stars continued to reign but offbeat themes, talented technicians and unlikely actors found a new audience willing to experiment.

A BLUFFER'S GUIDE

- Fuelled by the multiplex boom, with over 800 screens, Bollywood makes more films, at lower budgets.
- Conventional is passé; the more complicated the theme, the better it is.
- Stars may be missing but actors make their presence felt. The ever-growing tribe includes Abhay Deol, Konkona Sen Sharma and Ranvir Shorey.

By Rajat Kapoor |

In the summer of 1995, I shot my first feature film. It was called *Private Detective 2 Plus 2 Plus 1*. Well, at least the title was innovative. Seven years after graduating from the Film and Television Institute of India, Pune, finally we were making a feature film. It was cinematographer Rafey Mehmood and Oscar-winning sound recordist Resul Pookutty's first film. We were full of hope. The first roadblock came soon after the shooting was over: the production house that was funding it disbanded. We had to wait for a year-and-a-half to finish the film.

I remember it was New Year's eve in

1997 when I received the Censor certificate. We were full of hope again. The film would be released, I would be a bona fide filmmaker and that would open the doors to filmmaking. By then, I had written two other scripts. One was *Mithya*, the other one was *Raghu Romeo*. Nothing happened.

Private Detective never got released though a couple of thousand people must have seen it at previews and at a couple of film festivals, but nobody wanted to fund films that were cheap and had no stars in them. The 1990s was a terrible decade for wannabe filmmakers and I resigned myself to making a film every 10 years. I told myself, "over the next 50 years, you would have made five. Not bad." Not the best of the scenarios, but it wouldn't kill me.

A brand new century arrived, but nothing really changed. And I would never understand why producers would continue to risk Rs 20 crore on a project with someone they thought was a saleable star, and be willing to lose all their money—but not invest in a Rs 80-lakh film saying that it was too risky. That logic never made sense to me, but obviously they did not know any